

Guest Speaker Summary: Archer Aviation

Guest speakers from Archer Aviation came to speak to our class today. They are a San Jose-based company working in the advanced air mobility space. Archer has around 1800 employees, is listed on the NYSE, and has about 1.6 billion dollars in cash to fund the company. The company is built on partnerships with major airlines and technology companies, including United Airlines, Korean Air, Boeing, and NVIDIA.

Archer's main product is their Midnight model, an all-electric piloted air-taxi designed for trips below 100 miles but normally around 30 to 50 miles. It can reach speeds up to 120 miles per hour and flies 1500 ft above the ground. Archer is also working on unmanned aircraft systems for cargo, along with AI software and powertrain and battery technology.

The speaker showed that the company is in their "crawl" phase. They are working within existing aviation infrastructure, working with the FAA, and using existing VFR routes. Archer's biggest competitor is Joby Aviation. Archer is also the official partner of the 2028 LA Olympics, which will be a public showcase of the air taxi service.

The presentation also covered career paths from SJSU to their company. Although most of them catered to manufacturing and aviation, there are many positions that need to be quickly filled at this company, including flight followers and schedulers, maintenance technicians, repairmen, managers, supervisors, and support staff.

The biggest takeaway for me was how new industries and companies rely on existing infrastructure. With the regulations in place through many organizations such as the FAA, Archer is forced to comply and squeeze itself into this existing airspace by using rules and routes that aviation already uses, then scaling up from there. The "crawl, walk, run" approach drove the point that this company is still heavily in development. I was also surprised to see how many jobs they would need in the future as more aircraft are built. With AI software and connected aircraft being within the future reach, I can see where networking and security would fit in, since systems like these need to be reliable and secure.

The internship advice also stood out to me. A speaker described a path of interning and then working part-time during her time at SJSU. She used her experience and networking to go from internship to part-time to full-time with the company. It reinforced that internships are less about landing a single position and more about building your social network that will open the next doors for your career.